RANK FILES • COMPETITIVE ENGLISH SERIES

SUBJECT-VERB AGREEMENT

COMPLETE GRAMMAR GUIDE •

Comprehensive Rules & Exam Worksheets

> **Fundamental Rule of Grammar:** The verb in a sentence must always agree with its subject in **number** (singular or plural) and **person** (first, second, or third person).
> • *Singular Subject → Singular Verb* (e.g., `Shivam writes a letter.`)
> • *Plural Subject → Plural Verb* (e.g., `They write a letter.`)

CORE RULES & APPLICATION STANDARDS

RULE 01 Two Singular Subjects Joined by 'And'

When two or more singular nouns or pronouns are joined by the conjunction **'and'**, and they refer to separate persons or objects, a **plural verb** is used.

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Subject 1 + 'and' + Subject 2 → Plural Verb
```

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Ravi and Rakesh **are** playing in the park.
CORRECT	You and Amit **are** late today.
INCORRECT	~~Ravi and Rakesh is playing in the park.~~

RULE 02 Single Idea, Food Pairings & Compound Nouns

If two nouns joined by **'and'** express a single, unified idea, refer to the same person/thing, or form a well-known combined item/phrase, they take a **singular verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Bread and butter **is** my favorite breakfast. *(Single meal concept)*
CORRECT	Slow and steady **wins** the race. *(Single quality/maxim)*
CORRECT	This black and white tie **is** mine. *(One single item with two colors)*

RULE 03 Parenthetical Connectives (As well as, Along with, etc.)

When two subjects are joined by phrases like **along with, with, as well as, in addition to, besides, nothing, unlike, like, no less than**, the verb agrees strictly with the **FIRST subject** regardless of the second subject.

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First Subject + [along with / as well as / with / etc.] + Second Subject → Verb agrees with First Subject
```

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Rohan as well as his friends **is** playing. *(Subject is 'Rohan' - Singular)*
CORRECT	They along with their teacher **are** going on vacation. *(Subject is 'They' - Plural)*
INCORRECT	~~Rohan as well as his friends are playing.~~

RULE 04 Correlative Conjunctions (Either...or, Neither...nor, Not only...but also)

When two subjects are connected by **either...or, neither...nor, or, nor, not only...but also**, the verb agrees with the subject **NEAREST** to it.

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Subject 1 + [or / nor / but also] + Subject 2 (Nearest) → Verb agrees with Subject 2
```

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Neither Ram nor Rohan **is** coming today. *('Rohan' is singular)*
CORRECT	Not only Shyam but also his parents **were** present in the wedding. *('Parents' is plural)*

RULE 05 Distributive Expressions (Neither of, Either of, None of)

Phrases like **Neither of, Either of, None of, Each of** are followed by a **plural noun/pronoun**, but always take a **singular verb** because they refer to individual entities one at a time.

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Either of / Neither of / None of + Plural Noun/Pronoun → Singular Verb
```

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Neither of these two girls **is** clever.
CORRECT	Either of you **was** absent from the class.
INCORRECT	~~Neither of these two girls are clever.~~

RULE 06 Indefinite Pronouns (Somebody, Everyone, Each, Nothing, etc.)

Indefinite pronouns such as **somebody, everybody, each, nobody, anybody, everyone, everything, nothing, every, anything** take a **singular verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Nobody **knows** about the future.
CORRECT	Nothing **is** impossible if you have determination.
CORRECT	Each boy **is** good in Maths.

RULE 07 & 08 Quantifier Phrases (Most of, Half of, Some of, Plenty of, A lot of)

For phrases like **most of, half of, some of, enough of, plenty of, a lot of**, the verb agreement depends entirely on the noun that follows:

- If followed by an **uncountable noun** → **Singular verb**.
- If followed by a **countable plural noun** → **Plural verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Some milk **is** needed. *(Milk = Uncountable → Singular)*
CORRECT	Most of the work **has been** done. *(Work = Uncountable → Singular)*
CORRECT	Some questions **are** difficult. *(Questions = Countable Plural → Plural)*
CORRECT	Most of the boys **were** absent. *(Boys = Countable Plural → Plural)*

RULE 09 Expressions with 'More Than'

- **"More than one"** + Singular Countable Noun → **Singular Verb**.
- **"More than two/three/four"** + Plural Noun → **Plural Verb**.
- **"More + Plural Noun + than one"** → **Plural Verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	More than one boy **was** absent.
CORRECT	More than two boys **were** absent.
CORRECT	More teachers than one **are** present.

RULE 10 'A Number of' vs 'The Number of'

- **"A number of"** / **"A large number of"** / **"A great number of"** implies an indefinite large quantity and takes a **plural noun and plural verb**.
- **"The number of"** denotes a specific fixed total/figure and takes a **plural noun but a SINGULAR verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	A large number of cows **are** grazing in the field.
CORRECT	The number of children **is** twenty.
CORRECT	The number of passengers in Metro **is** increasing.

RULE 11 'Many', 'A Great Many' vs 'Many A'

- **Many, A great many, A good many, Several, Few, A few, Various, Both** take a **plural subject and plural verb**.
- Exceptional Exception: **"Many a / Many an"** is followed strictly by a **singular noun and singular verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	A great many actors **are** coming.
CORRECT	Very few students **are** hard working.
CORRECT	Many a boy **has** come for the class. *(Not: Many a boy have come)*

RULE 12 'The' + Adjective (Representing a Class)

When article **'The'** is placed before an adjective (e.g., *the poor, the rich, the honest, the blind, the weak, the French*), it converts the adjective into a plural noun representing the entire group/class. Hence, it takes a **plural verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	The poor **are** generally hardworking. *(The poor = Poor people)*
CORRECT	The rich **are** not always happy.

RULE 13 Structures with 'Nothing But' / 'Everything But'

When a sentence begins with **"Nothing but"** or **"Everything but"**, the verb is always **singular**, regardless of whether the noun following 'but' is singular, plural, or uncountable.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Nothing but milk **is** sold. *(Uncountable Noun)*
CORRECT	Nothing but birds **was** seen. *(Plural Noun, yet Singular Verb)*
CORRECT	Everything but books **is** sold.

RULE 14 The 'One of the' Construction

The phrase **"One of the"** is always followed by a **plural noun/pronoun**, but takes a **singular verb** because the real subject is 'One'.

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One of the + Plural Noun + Singular Verb
```

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	One of the boys **was** playing chess.
CORRECT	One of the girls **is** crying.

RULE 15 Definite Units of Measurement / Amounts

• When a numeral + plural noun represents a **single collective unit** of distance, weight, height, or money, use a **singular verb**.
• However, if it refers to **different individual units/items** or divided spending, use a **plural verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Ten thousand rupees **is** a good amount. *(Single lump sum)*
CORRECT	Twelve hundred rupees **have been spent** on shopping. *(Spent separately in items)*

RULE 16 Relative Pronouns (Who, Which, That) & Antecedent Agreement

When relative pronouns **who, which, that** are used to connect a clause, the verb following the relative pronoun must agree in number and person with its **antecedent** (the noun/pronoun immediately preceding the relative pronoun).

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Antecedent + [Who / Which / That] + Verb (Agrees with Antecedent)
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Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	I, who **am** a cricketer, play here. *(Antecedent is 'I' → Verb 'am')*
CORRECT	The man who **was** sitting there is my father. *(Antecedent is 'man' → Verb 'was')*

RULE 17 Unreal Conditions & Subjunctive Mood (If, As if, I wish)

In hypothetical statements, wishes, imaginary situations, or unfulfilled desires introduced by **if, as if, as though, I wish, would that**, the verb **'were'** is used with all subjects (singular and plural alike).

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	I wish I **were** the President of India. *(Imaginary wish)*
CORRECT	If I **were** you, I would have finished the work.

RULE 18 Articles with Two Nouns Joined by 'And'

• If an article (a/an/the) or possessive adjective is placed before **ONLY the first noun**, it means both nouns refer to the **same person/thing → Singular Verb**.
• If an article is placed before **BOTH nouns**, it refers to **two distinct persons/things → Plural Verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	**The** Chairman and Managing Director **has** arrived. *(One person holding both posts)*
CORRECT	**The** director and **the** producer **have** come. *(Two different individuals)*

RULE 19 Usage of 'All' (Countable vs Uncountable)

• When **'All'** denotes everything or an uncountable mass/situation → **Singular verb**.
• When **'All'** refers to a countable number of individuals or items → **Plural verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	All **is** good now a days. *(Everything in general - Uncountable)*
CORRECT	All **have** gone to Mumbai. *(All members - Countable plural)*

RULE 20 'Amount of' / 'Quantity of'

The phrases **"Amount of"** and **"Quantity of"** are strictly followed by **uncountable nouns** and take a **singular verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	The amount of milk **is** sufficient.

RULE 21 Nouns Existing Only in Plural Form

Certain nouns exist only in the plural form and cannot be made singular by removing 's'. They always take a **plural verb**.

Examples: Scissors, tongs, pliers, trousers, pants, pajamas, shorts, sunglasses, gallows, riches, savings, congratulations, regards, alms, wages, belongings, troops, tactics.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Where **are** my pants?
CORRECT	His new sunglasses **are** quite expensive.

RULE 22 Uncountable Nouns Appearing Singular

Nouns such as **Scenery, Poetry, Furniture, Hair, Business, Mischief, Information, Luggage, Work, Traffic, Stationery, Equipment, Evidence, Electricity, Behaviour, Crockery** are uncountable. They do not take 's/es' and always take a **singular verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	The scenery of Switzerland **mesmerizes** everyone.
CORRECT	The furniture that I bought yesterday **is** really comfortable.

RULE 23 Nouns Plural in Form but Singular in Meaning

Subjects, branches of knowledge, diseases, or games ending in 's' (e.g., **Economics, Ethics, Mathematics, Politics, Rickets, Billiards**) are singular in meaning and take a **singular verb**.

> **Important Exception:** When these terms are particularized, modified, or preceded by a possessive pronoun (e.g., *My mathematics, The politics of our country*), they refer to specific data, skills, or views and take a **PLURAL verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Economics **is** an easy subject. *(General subject)*
CORRECT	Politics of our country **are** dirty. *(Particularized political affairs)*

RULE 24 Nouns Singular in Form but Plural in Meaning

Nouns such as **Cattle, Cavalry, Infantry, Children, Gentry, People, Poultry, Folk** appear singular in form (no 's' at the end) but are inherently plural in meaning. They always take a **plural verb**.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	Cattle **are** grazing in the field.
INCORRECT	~~Cattles are grazing in the field. / Cattle is grazing.~~

RULE 25 **Collective Nouns as Single Units**

Collective nouns (e.g., **pride, bundle, herd, flock, committee, jury, team**) take a **singular verb** when they act as a single, undivided whole.

Type	Example Sentences
CORRECT	The pride of lions **is** hunting.
CORRECT	This bundle of sticks **is** heavy.

PRACTICE EXERCISE — ERROR DETECTION

Directions: Find out the error in each of the following sentences, if there is no error, mark (e). Avoid punctuation mistakes.

1. Treasure Island is (a)/ one of the best pirate stories (b)/ that **were** (c)/ever written. (d)/ No error (e)

2. Surely, she must feel bitter (a)/about that fact, and yet (b)/neither her voice nor her expressions **gives** any (c)/ indication that she feel animosity. (d)/ No error (e)

3. This is one of the (a)/most interesting **novel** (b)/that has (c)/appeared this year. (d)/ No error (e)

4. If you are one of those tech addicts (a)/who can't helped but spend most (b)/your waking life glued to your cell phone, (c)/ relief may finally be at hand. (d)/ No error (e)

5. We lament the excessive (a)/delicacy of his ideas, which **prevent** one (c)/from grasping them.(d)/ No error (e)

6. (a) The invention of AC, T.V (b) and such other appliances (c) **have** not been without (d) some effect. / (e) No error.

7. (a) Each of the students / (b) in the science class has / (c) to prepare **their** / (d) own research paper this semester. / (e) No error.

8. (a) Everyone of the novels / (b) you suggested / (c) **are** not / (d) worth reading. / (e) No error.

9. (a) There **is** / (b) only one of his / (c) movies, that / (d) are interesting. / (e) No error.

10. (a) Knowledge of / (b) at least two subjects / (c) **are** required to / (d) pass the examination. / (e) No error.

11. (a) It is I / (b) who **is** / (c) to blame / (d) for these complications. / (e) No error.

12. (a) Patience as well as perseverance / (b) **are** necessary / (c) for success. / (d) in life. / (e) No error.

13. (a) In Canada / (b) My brother with his wife / (c) **were** present / (d) at the function. / (e) No error.

14. (a) A hot and / (b) a cold spring / (c) **is** found / (d) near each other. / (e) No error.

15. (a) Neither of the / (b) paths / (c) **lead** / (d) to the school. / (e) No error.

16. (a) One of my ambitions / (b) **are** / (c) to become a cricketer / (d) one day. / (e) No error.

17. (a) The whole block of flats / (b) including two clinics / (c) **were** destroyed / (d) in earthquake. / (e) No error.